MAKE IT DO · FREE SHEET

What things cost the year you were born

1949

The everyday things	1949	Reference	In our house
A pound of white bread per pound	14¢	$1.87 2025	_____
A dozen eggs per dozen	70¢	$4.25 2025	_____
Half a gallon of milk delivered to the door	42¢	$2.03 2025	_____
A pound of butter per pound	73¢	$4.76 2025	_____
A pound of round steak per pound	85¢	$8.86 2025	_____
A pound of bacon per pound	67¢	$7.02 2025	_____
A pound of coffee per pound	55¢	$8.18 2025	_____
Five pounds of sugar 5-pound bag	48¢	$5.12 2025	_____
Ten pounds of potatoes 10-pound bag	55¢	$9.63 2025	_____
A gallon of gas regular, with taxes	27¢	$3.26 2025	_____
A stamp for a letter first-class, first ounce	3¢	82¢ 2026	_____

The everyday things	1949	Reference	In our house
An hour's pay at the federal minimum from Oct. 24, 1945	40¢	$7.25 2026	_____

The names in the nursery

Girls: Linda, Mary, Patricia, Barbara, Susan.
Boys: James, Robert, John, William, Michael.

Read the dates beside the prices

The reference food and gas figures are the supplied BLS 2025 averages. The stamp and federal wage figures are dated 2026. These are not live prices. Milk then was home-delivered; the reference is store-bought. Prices are rounded to the nearest cent. Original averages can include tenths of a cent.

$1 in 1949 had approximately the buying power of $13.53 in 2025, using CPI-U. A general price index is not a family budget.

Where the numbers come from

- U.S. Bureau of the Census, Historical Statistics of the United States, Colonial Times to 1970, Part 1, Series E 187-202, Retail Prices of Selected Foods in U.S. Cities (BLS), p. 213
- U.S. Energy Information Administration, Annual Energy Review 2011 (DOE/EIA-0384(2011)), Table 5.24 Retail Motor Gasoline and On-Highway Diesel Fuel Prices, Leaded Regular gasoline, U.S. city average, Nominal, AER 2011 p. 173 (PDF p. 193 of aer.pdf) prints selected years
- United States Postal Service, Historian, "Rates for Domestic Letters Since 1863" (September 2021), Table "Postage in Cents, per Ounce" (effective dates), p. 1 (single-page PDF)
- U.S. Department of Labor, Wage and Hour Division, History of Federal Minimum Wage Rates Under the Fair Labor Standards Act, 1938-2009 (1938 Act column)

Reference prices: BLS Average Price Data, 2025 monthly means; USPS Forever stamp, November 2026; DOL federal minimum wage. Names: SSA national birth-year data. Full linked records and exact series: makeitdoshow.com/1949.

From *Everyday Life in 1950s America, in Real Color Film* · Make It Do